POLITICS | Challenges

HATE, HUBRIS AND HARD STATISTICS: Debating political campaigns and social media narratives

POLITICAL SLUGFEST

In a fiery session, the BJP's IT department head Amit Malviya and Congress social media chief Supriya Shrinate squared off on various issues, giving us an insight on how closely contested control of the digital and social media space is likely to be ahead of the 2024 polls. In his opening remarks, Malviya touched on the social media-enabled 'democratisation of discourse' while going on to list the NDA government's achievements under PM Modi through figures between 2014 and 2022. Shrinate, in her reply, rejected the figures and instead posed a question to Malviya—if all was well, what was the need to spread fake news? She also mentioned that Malviya had been flagged for spreading fake news by social media platforms, something the latter claimed as a badge of honour since even former US president Donald Trump was flagged for the same reasons. The two continued to spar, with Malviya listing the faux pas made by Rahul Gandhi and Shrinate responding with a list of similar blunders by Prime Minister Modi. ■

AMIT MALVIYA
BJP National Information and Technology Dept in-charge, West Bengal unit co-in-charge

There has been a democratisation of the discourse, which is a very powerful idea. Most people don't understand its impact.... With the advent of social media, this has changed because people have an opinion

SUPRIYA SHRINATE
Chairperson, Social Media and Digital Platform, Congress

Let's talk about the elephant in the room... why do you have this urgent desire, this great need, to weaponise fake news, to weaponise misinformation?



BANDEEP SINGH

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- What is said in Delhi reaches the farthest corners of India. And it is not media that takes the message across but social media
- The data says BJP leaders and the party have a bigger following on social media platforms but the Congress gets more retweets and likes